

143 areas. In the first bid book, however, it was noticeable that what the whole of Germany associated with Chemnitz during the application phase, i.e. from August 2018 onward, hardly played a role in the application, namely the riots of right-wing extremist and populists in August 2018. Nevertheless, Chemnitz presented an extensive application overall and demonstrated a good network of cultural actors in the city and the region, so that the selection panel recommended the city for the next round. Dresden (dropped out of competition in 2019) Under the motto "New Home Dresden" ("Neue Heimat Dresden"), the Saxon capital presented concepts and projects in its bid book I that were intended to counteract the social division of the city. In numerous artistic actions, some of which were supported by the project office with microcredits, as well as in panel discussions and participative projects such as a postcard campaign, the concept of "home" ("Heimat") was played with in order to find new narratives for the city. This was not only about an open attitude towards immigrants, but also about major present and future tasks that fundamentally change people's lives, such as digitisation. Although Dresden's approach was highly innovative, relevant and authentic, various influential opinion makers such as the German Cultural Council (Deutscher Kulturrat 2019: 14) and the *Süddeutsche Zeitung* (Heidtmann/ Nimz 2019: online) contrasted the two Saxon competing cities in a questionably simplistic way: poor Chemnitz, which is preceded by a problematic reputation, versus dazzling, privileged Dresden. Whether Dresden really dropped out of the competition at an early stage against the background of this simplistic black-and-white portrayal in the media cannot be proven. In any case, many could not understand the selection panel's assessment (see the Expert Panel's Report of the Pre-Selection Stage / Selection of the European Capital of Culture 2025 in Germany, https://ec.europa.eu/programmes/creative-europe/actions/capitals-culture_en, and a comment at Jacobsen 2020: 22). Gera (dropped out of competition in 2019) The Thuringian city with only 95,000 inhabitants dared to go off the beaten track. An association of committed citizens initiated the application and pushed it forward years before the city made a - relatively modest - contribution to the application. Their bid book I presented the historical heritage, and perhaps this common understanding of the interpretation of the past was already a benefit to the city society. However, too few feasible visions of the future were presented, which could be achieved with the ECoC title. All in all, Gera had probably shown too little commitment in the application process to meet the demanding and far-reaching requirements, especially with regard to the other top-class competing cities. Hanover The capital of Lower Saxony entered the competition relatively late and then immediately faced special cultural policy challenges: a new mayor was elected during this period, and there was also a change in the cultural administration after a few squabbles, when the former head of the culture department was brought to court. Nevertheless, Hanover managed to submit an exceptionally artistic bid book I, which was awarded a prize not least for its design. Positive aspects of the content were its distinct European dimension and a professionally positioned management, which led to the expectation that the ECoC programme would be very feasible in the fair and Expo city.